

Rossini composed a number of more serious operas for the prima donna Isabella Colbran, among them *Othello* and *The Lady of the Lake*. When the pair first met, she was Barbaja's mistress, but she soon transferred her affections to Rossini and the couple were eventually married in 1822. Two years later, they moved to Paris, where Gioachino reached the pinnacle of his career. The French capital was regarded as the center of the operatic world and Rossini was greeted there like a conquering hero. He was appointed director of the Théâtre-Italien, commissioned to produce work for the Opéra, and honored by the French king. Rossini responded by composing his crowning masterpiece, *William Tell*.



ISABELLA COLBRAN, c. 1835

The sensational Spanish soprano's voice was described as "sweet and mellow, with a rich